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05 JUN 2024



**UNIVERSITY OF IBADAN**  
**DIRECTORATE OF AFFILIATED INSTITUTIONS**  
**BIGARD MEMORIAL SEMINARY, ENUGU**

BMS/IB/2997 ..... Candidate's Number (write very clearly)  
 PHIL 3 ..... Level of Study  
 ARIS ..... Faculty/College  
 PHILOSOPHY ..... Department/Course

HERMENEUTICS ..... Title of Paper  
 5th JUNE, 2024. .... Date

Examination (insert official title)  
 of the Examination for which you  
 have entered, as it appears at  
 the head of the question paper

**DIRECTIONS TO CANDIDATES**

1. Write on both sides of the pages (except in Mathematics)
2. Begin each answer on a fresh page
3. Write the number of each question at the top of each page.
4. All rough work must be crossed through, and enclosed within this cover.
5. If supplementary books are used, they must be fastened at together at the end of this book and inside the cover. Answers must not be written on the supplementary books unless all the leaves in this book have already been used.
6. In your own interest you should enter in the space provided below, the numbers of the questions which you have attempted (with sub-sections where necessary).
7. In no circumstances must answer books used or unused, be removed from the Examination Room by a Candidate.
8. Candidates are warned that importance is attached by the examination to accuracy and clearness of expression.
9. Please note that there is severe penalty for cheating at any examination.

1, 2, 3

**NUMBERS OF THE ANSWERS**  
 in the order in which they have been written.

All students of the University of Ibadan are expected to show academic integrity at all times. Understanding this, I solemnly declare that I shall not be involved in any malpractice including soliciting, giving, receiving or using unauthorised aid in this examination.

Signature of student

For Examiner's  
Use Only

| Question No. | Mark |
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Situate the emergence of the hermeneutical current in contemporary African philosophy within the context and dynamics of the struggle to defend and justify the existence of African philosophy.

### Outline

- ① Introduction
- ② Meaning of Hermeneutics
- ③ Struggle to defend and justify the existence of African Philosophy.
- ④ Hermeneutical current
- ⑤ Evaluation

### ① Introduction

Hermeneutical current in contemporary African philosophy is one of the trends that depicts the full blossoming of African philosophy but then before African philosophy got to its stage of full blossoming, it passed through stages of presumed non-existence, making claims by educated Africans about its existence, then the denial by Europeans and its final stage of hermeneutics.

### ② Meaning of Hermeneutics

Hermeneutics is the theory and methodology of interpretation. It is the study of interpretation. Originally, Hermeneutics is attributed or associated with the biblical text or biblical study. Traditionally, Hermeneutic is concerned with the written texts such as literature, religion and law.



Etymologically, Hermeneutics is from the Greek word, *hermeneutikos* meaning "interpretation" or associated with interpretation. It is from this Greek derivative that hermeneutic derives its meaning. The verbal form is "hermeneuein" meaning "to interpret". The root word of hermeneutics is associated with Hermes, the Greek messenger god, responsible for passing messages from God or gods to humans. Thus in the Acts of the apostle, Barnabas was called Hermes and Paul was called Zeus because Barnabas was the interpreter of Paul.

### ③ Struggle to defend and justify the existence of African philosophy.

Africa as a continent was colonized by Europeans. During this process of colonization, Africans were made to believe they had no philosophy, identity and history. They used ideological arms to wipe out African history claiming that the history of Africa began with the arrival of the colonial elites. Thus, it was believed that education in the sub-saharan African began with the coming of the whiteman.

The European colonizers discarded African mode of education, transmission of information and documentation. Thus, they established the western education, way of life and philosophy. This was the stage of presumed non-existence of African philosophy. It was the first stage of the struggle



to defend and justify the existence of African philosophy.

As a result of the education of Africans, some well-educated Africans began to ask questions and make claims about the fact that Africans have the capacity to engage in philosophical enterprise. This stage of making claims about the existence of African philosophy is the second stage. Ethnophilosophers belong to this stage because they were among the first to make claims about African philosophy, affirming that Africans have the capacity to reason.

Furthermore, this claims by Africans was denied by the western elites on the ground that making claims about the existence of African philosophy is absurd because Africans do not have the intellectual capacity to philosophize. They dismissed the claims to the existence of African philosophy proposing that the claims were coming from cultural anthropology. This position was held by western philosophers like Kant and Hegel. This stage of making denial was the third stage.

This denial of the existence of African philosophy spurred well meaning African scholars to rise above the mental and psychological domination of the European colonizers and make extra effort towards establishing the existence of African philosophy. This efforts by African scholars led to the emergence of various trends in African philosophy such as professional trend, ideological trend, philosophical sagacity and then hermeneutical trend. This is the stage of full



blossoming of African philosophy.

#### ④ Hermeneutical Current

As earlier stated, Hermeneutics is the study of interpretation. In the African philosophical context, it refers to the attempt towards establishing the possibility and conditions of existence of African philosophy.

Okere and other proponents of the hermeneutical current posit that hermeneutics is an epistemological tool mediating between philosophy and culture. Hermeneutic therefore, is the panacea and method of deriving authentic African philosophy from culture. Okere was a major proponent of the hermeneutical current and he wrote his thesis defending the existence of African philosophy. In his thesis entitled; "African philosophy: a historical hermeneutical approach interpretation of the condition of it's possibility", he sought to propose an authentic method of African philosophy. He proposes hermeneutics is the ideal approach to African philosophy positing that it serves as a justification and defense of the existence of African philosophy.

Therefore for Okere, the light of hermeneutic must be shone on the cultural experiences of people in order to derive the authentic philosophy. There must be an active thinker with the capacity to ask relevant questions and interpretation in order for philosophy to be derived from culture.



### ⑤ Evaluation

The stages of struggle to defend and justify the existence of African philosophy presents the gradual growth and development of African philosophy. It is also pertinent to note that these stages of struggles aided the effective growth and development of African philosophy to its final stage of full blossoming.

### ⑥ Conclusions

African philosophers must then make use of the rich African heritage as raw material in philosophizing both within and outside the African worldview.



Is it right to qualify Theophilus Okere's attitude to ethnophilosophy as encompassing both respect and reproach? Give detailed reasons for your answer

① Introduction

② Meaning of ethnophilosophy and the argument of some ethnophilosophers

③ Okere critique of ethnophilosophy.

④ Okere's proposal

⑤ Evaluation

⑥ Conclusion

① Introduction

I wish to favour the argument that Theophilus Okere's attitude towards ethnophilosophy encompasses both respect and reproach. Okere agreed with the ethnophilosophers that philosophy is discovered within the confines of culture but he disagreed with them in equating culture to philosophy proposing that their errors was as a result of hasty conclusions and overgeneralization of concepts therefore Okere respected their viewpoints but then went further to correct and clarify their errors.

② Meaning of ethnophilosophy and the argument of some ethnophilosophers.

Ethnophilosophy refers to the initial claims made towards establishing the existence of African



philosophy. Ethnophilosophers were of the view that the culture of a people can be equated to their philosophy thus giving room for replacement of one with another. They proposed that philosophy is synonymous with culture.

Some ethnophilosophers are Placid Tempels, Alexis Kagame and John Mbiti. Their arguments follows thus;

### Placid Tempels

Tempels was a Belgian missionary, who lived among the Bantu (Baluba) people. Tempels after studying the culture of Bantu people discovered that the Bantu attributed everything to vital force. Tempels then concluded that the Bantu idea and concept of vital force is their philosophy.

### Alexis Kagame

Kagame was interested in the language of Rwandan people. He posited that there are structures in the language of Rwanda which had deeper conceptualization beyond the immediate visible. He thus concluded that the structures in the language of the Rwanda people is their philosophy. Therefore, language is the gateway to the philosophy of the Rwandans.

### John Mbiti

Mbiti studied the concept of time among the Kikuyu people of East Africa. He noted that the

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Question.....

Conception of time among the Africans and the Europeans were different. Among the European there was a linear conception of time; made up of past, present, and future, however among the African there was no such linear conception of time. The conception of time among Africans was based on an extended past, the present and the near future. Mbiti thus made a juxtaposition of his viewpoints and concluded that their philosophy is found in their conception of time.

### ③ Okere's Critique of ethnophilosophy.

Okere's position was that the philosophy of a people cannot be separated from their culture. Culture gives the starting point of departure of philosophical enterprise but then he noted that it is wrong to equate culture to philosophy. Okere criticized this view by the ethnophilosophers thus;

Okere criticized Placid Tempels' conclusions that the Bantu concept and idea of vital force is their philosophy. He posited that the fact that the Bantu people attributed everything there is to vital force is not a sufficient argument that it is their philosophy.

Moreover, Okere criticized Kagame's conclusions that the structures in the language of the Rwandan people amounts to their philosophy. The mere fact that there are deeper conceptualization in the language of the Rwandan is not enough to show that it is



their philosophy.

Okere criticized Mbiti's conclusions that the concept of time among the ~~Kikuyu~~ people of East Africa is their philosophy since he did not make any distinction between time as social, scientific or philosophical.

#### ④ Okere's Proposal

Okere proposed that the method to authentic African philosophy is through the hermeneutics of culture, hence there must be interpretation of culture before philosophy is derived from it.

He proposed that one must encounter a culture before he then makes use of hermeneutical investigation to discover the philosophy embedded within it. The culture of people have hidden meaning latent in them, therefore hermeneutical investigation must be applied in order to drive out the meaning latent in them.

#### ⑤ Evaluation

Okere's proposal of hermeneutics as the method to authentic African philosophy seems to be flawed on the ground that hermeneutics of culture leads to relativism in philosophy but Okere was not arguing for the place of relativism rather



Question.....

he was focused on the idea of hermeneutics as interpretation but then since interpretation involves relativism therefore relativism cannot be avoided. One can therefore argue for relativism thus engaging in further philosophical enterprise which is the bedrock of philosophy, that is, "to ask further questions"

### ⑥ Conclusion

Therefore, I conclude that it is right to qualify Meophilus Okere's attitude to ethnophilosophy as encompassing both respect and reproach because he did not only criticize their viewpoint rather he also built on their argument of culture as inseparable from philosophy.

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"Philosophy is inherently interpretative. It is the product of language, context and history, and hence inextricably linked to culture." (Komo, 2017)  
How does this claim affirm or deny Okere's thesis proposing hermeneutics as the right methodology for African philosophy.

① Introduction

② Okere's thesis

③ Culture, philosophy and Hermeneutics

④ How the statement affirms Okere's thesis

① Introduction

This statement by Komo, "Philosophy is inherently interpretative. It is the product of language context and history and hence inextricably linked to culture" strongly affirms Okere's thesis proposing hermeneutics as the right methodology for African philosophy.

② Okere's thesis

Okere was interested in laying out the method and pathway to authentic African philosophy. He aimed at showing the proper methodology through which one can arrive at authentic African philosophy.



Question.....

Okere therefore proposed hermeneutics as the pathway that will lead one to discover authentic African philosophy. Hermeneutics is the theory of interpretation thus Okere proposes that hermeneutics is that which happens to culture in order to derive philosophy from it. Therefore, philosophy cannot exist outside the confines of the culture or way of life of a people. Culture gives the starting point of departure of philosophical enterprise.

Okere in his doctoral thesis entitled; African Philosophy: A historical hermeneutical investigation of the condition of its possibility which he defended in the University of Belgium, Louvain La neuve was no longer proving the possibility of African philosophy. He was of the viewpoint that African philosophy cannot be denied ~~there~~ then he was now aimed at showing the pathway that will lead to authentic African philosophy through hermeneutics.

### ③ Culture, philosophy and Hermeneutics

These are the three major areas of concentration of Okere's argument. Culture cannot be separated from philosophy. Culture is the starting point of any philosophical enterprise. Then, the light of Hermeneutics must be shone on culture in order to derive authentic African philosophy.

Culture is the people's way of life. It is the day to day life experiences of individual in their environmental reality.



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Philosophy is the search for meaning. Etymologically, it is the love of wisdom.

Hermeneutics is the theory of interpretation. According to Okere, it is the epistemological tool mediating between philosophy and culture.

#### ④ How Komo's statement affirms Okere's thesis:

The statement by Komo affirms Okere's thesis on the ground that it recognizes the fact that philosophy is context-dependent, and cannot exist outside culture, just like Okere noted.

Also the statement recognizes the facts that philosophy is interpretative and thus this means that the best approach to discover the philosophy of a people is through interpretation. Therefore, hermeneutic which is the study of interpretation serves as the adequate method to authentic African philosophy as proposed by Okere.

The statement recognizes the fact that philosophy is based on the language of a people. Thus, just as Okere was influenced by Paul Ricoeur's view that language is symbol and symbols are pregnant with meaning, Komo's statement attest to the same fact.

Language therefore must be interpreted by hermeneutics in order to derive the hidden meaning.

Finally, the statement also recognizes the fact that philosophy is based on history. Thus as Okere was influenced by Heidegger's view of Dasein as a



situated being defined by facticity, historicity and relatedness. Komo's statement recognizes and attests to this view of history as an important factor in philosophy. Also the idea of context as presented in Gadamer who influenced Okere was also recognized in Komo's statement.

It is therefore right to conclude that Komo's statement summarizes Okere thesis; philosophy is based on culture, and it is through interpretation that the philosophy within a culture is driven out. Hence, for philosophy to emerge from culture, there must be an active thinker with the capacity to ask relevant questions and then there must be interpretation. Culture is a condition sine-qua-non because it is on culture that the light of hermeneutic will be shone in order to derive philosophy.

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